

The Proposal

Sent within 48 hours of the walkthrough.

What it's for: making it easy to say yes, and making a price comparison harder than one number against another. Most janitorial proposals are a price and a task list, which trains the buyer to shop on price alone. Give them something else to compare.

Two to four pages. A twelve-page proposal doesn't read as thorough — it reads as padded.

The seven sections

1. Cover

Their company, their building address, the date, your details. Nothing else.

2. What we understood

Their words, back to them. Three or four sentences from what they told you.

*“You moved into the MacArthur building in August and need nightly service across roughly 4,200 square feet, with particular attention to the restrooms and the entry glass. You mentioned the thing that would make you call is a restroom that hasn't been touched.”**

This is the most important section and almost nobody includes it. It proves you listened, and it frames everything after it against their problem instead of your service list.

Every sentence here must come from something they actually said. Nothing invented.

3. Scope of work

Specific and countable. Not *“restrooms cleaned and sanitized”* but:

Restrooms (2) — *nightly: fixtures cleaned and disinfected, mirrors, partitions spot-cleaned, floors mopped, dispensers restocked, waste removed.*

Weekly: *partitions fully wiped, grout detail, vents dusted.*

Break it out by area and frequency. If it isn't written here, it isn't in the contract — and that protects both of you.

4. What's not included

Floor restoration, carpet extraction, window exteriors, post-construction, biohazard, day porter — whichever apply, with a price if they want them added.

Stating exclusions plainly builds more trust than leaving them out. It also prevents the argument in month three that ends the contract.

5. Three options

	Essential	Standard ← recommended	Complete
Frequency	3× weekly	5× weekly	5× weekly + day porter
Restrooms	3×	Nightly	Nightly + midday check
Floor care	Quarterly buff	Quarterly buff + annual strip/wax	Monthly buff + 2× strip/wax
Glass	Monthly	Twice-weekly entry detail	Weekly, all interior
Supplies	You provide	Included	Included
Inspections	—	Monthly, with written report	Monthly + quarterly review
Monthly	\$X	\$Y	\$Z

Mark the middle one recommended and say why in one line. Three options change the question from "is this too expensive?" to "which one do I want?" — a better question for both of you.

Price the tiers on real cost differences. Fake tiers built to make the middle look good are obvious to anyone who's bought this before.

6. How it works

Start date · transition plan for the first two weeks · your supervisor's name and mobile · inspection cadence and what the report contains · how they raise an issue and your response time · insurance and bonding, certificate attached · background-check policy.

The response-time commitment does more work than anything else on the page. Most complaints about cleaning companies are about responsiveness, not cleaning.

7. Terms

Monthly price and what triggers a review · term and notice period · payment terms · a plain-English cancellation clause.

Offer a 30-day out. It costs almost nothing — someone who wants to leave will leave — and it removes the biggest objection to switching vendors.

Sending it

Email the PDF and say you'll call. Don't attach and vanish; don't phone without sending.

**"Proposal attached for the MacArthur building. Three options — I've marked the one I'd recommend and why. I'll give you a call Thursday to walk through it, or reply any time if something's*

unclear."*

Then actually call on Thursday. That call is where the questions surface. Emailed proposals nobody follows up on are how deals go quiet.

Claims

Everything about them traces to what they told you. Everything about you is true.

Never	Instead
"Your current cleaner is failing"	"You mentioned the restrooms have been inconsistent" — only if they said it
"100% satisfaction guaranteed"	State the actual remedy: response time, re-clean policy
Client logos you don't have permission for	Real references, with permission, or none
A statistic you can't source	Your own numbers, or nothing
"Award-winning" with no award	Leave it out

In a market where owners talk to each other, an invented reference gets found out.

The nine objections

Structure: acknowledge → clarify → isolate → respond → confirm the next step. Don't argue.

"You're more expensive." Usually not about money — it's not knowing what differs.

*"Can I ask what their scope covers? Often the gap is frequency or supplies. If they're 3× weekly and we're nightly, that's the difference, and I can quote you a 3× option so you're comparing the same thing."**

Re-scope to match, or explain the difference. **Don't cut price to match a different scope.**

"We're happy with our current cleaner." Not a rejection.

*"Good — that's how it should be. I'd just ask to be the second call if anything changes. When's your contract up for renewal?"**

"We need to think about it." Usually an unaddressed question or an absent decision maker.

"Of course. Is there part of the proposal you'd want more detail on, or is it more about timing?"

Then: *"What would need to be true for this to be a yes?"*

"Send me references." A buying signal. Have three ready, same segment, with permission. If you don't have any yet, say so and offer a trial period instead. Honesty outperforms deflection here.

"Can you do it cheaper?" Never a flat yes. Trade something.

**"I can get to that number — it'd mean 4× weekly instead of nightly, or you supplying consumables.*

*Which works better?"**

"We're getting more quotes."

**"Makes sense. Two things worth comparing: whether supplies are included, and what response time*

*they'll commit to in writing."**

"We'll handle it in-house."

"That can work. The thing most places underestimate is coverage when someone's out sick."

Follow up in 90 days.

"Corporate decides this." A qualification failure. Ask for the contact, then move on.

Silence. Not an objection — a process failure. Five touches over about 17 days, then stop.

Closing

Ask directly. Most cleaning contracts are lost to nobody asking.

"Does the Standard option look right, or would you want to adjust anything?"

"I can have the agreement over this afternoon and we'd start Monday the 15th. Does that work?"

When they're stalling but positive:

"What's holding it up — the price, the scope, or is it just not the priority this month?"

That question is uncomfortable and it's the most useful one in the sale. Any of the three answers is something you can act on. Silence isn't.

Never: fake deadlines, invented discounts that expire, "I have another client interested in that slot." In a small local market, manufactured urgency is remembered.

Real constraints are fine: *"If we're starting the 15th I'd need to know by Thursday to schedule the crew."* True, checkable, and it works.

When you lose

Always ask, in one email:

**"No problem at all — appreciate you letting me know. Would you mind telling me what the deciding*

*factor was? It genuinely helps me.”**

Most people answer. Record it as a category, not a paragraph: price, incumbent retained, awarded to a competitor, no decision, scope mismatch, timing.

Pattern across losses	What it means
Mostly price	Your cost model or your targeting is off
Mostly incumbent retained	Your triggers are too late — you're arriving after the decision
Mostly no decision	You're not qualifying hard enough before the walkthrough
Mostly scope mismatch	Tighten who you target

One loss is noise. Ten losses are a diagnosis — and only if you recorded them the same way.

Then put them in your nurture list with a review date. Losing a bid is the start of a relationship with a building whose contract will come up again.